

This kitchen.



Your oven is not the oven the recipe was written in

Domestic ovens are routinely fifteen or twenty degrees out, and they are hotter at the back. That single fact is behind most of the cakes that sink and the chicken that is done on one side. Put a cheap oven thermometer on the middle shelf, set the dial to 180, wait twenty minutes and write down what it actually says. Every recipe you keep in here can then carry the real number.

THE OVEN Dial against thermometer

Set to 180, it reads _____ So it runs _____
Fan / conventional _____ Hot spot is _____

Shelf we use for baking _____

Grill, and how close _____

THE HOB What "medium" means here

Gas, electric or induction _____

Our medium is _____ Our low is _____

THE PANS WE ACTUALLY OWN Sizes, not adjectives

PAN OR TIN	SIZE	WHAT IT IS FOR
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

WHO WE COOK FOR

Usually _____ At a push _____

ALLERGIES AND THE ABSOLUTE NOS First

WILL NOT EAT, AND THERE IS NO ARGUING

ALWAYS IN THE CUPBOARD So a recipe can say "the usual"

NEVER IN, AND HAS TO BE BOUGHT

WHAT THIS KITCHEN CANNOT DO Honestly

SERVES HANDS ON START TO PLATE CAN BE DONE AHEAD

	FOR	FOR
WHAT, AND HOW MUCH		

WHAT, AND HOW MUCH

FOR

FOR

I

2

3

4

5

6

7

8

Pan or tin

Dial Really

What else it needs

Do this bit the day before

The second time.



3
CARD

METHOD, CONTINUED

9 _____

10 _____

11 _____

12 _____

13 _____

14 _____

15 _____

16 _____

17 _____

18 _____

SERVE IT WITH

WHO LIKED IT, AND WHO DID NOT Before next time

The recipe is not finished the first time you cook it

The first cook tells you almost nothing except whether it is worth a second. The second is where it becomes yours: less liquid, ten minutes longer, half the chilli, the onions started earlier. Write the change down **on the day**, in one line — a month later you will remember that you changed something and not what.

COOKED, AND CHANGED Tick if the change stays

DATE	WHAT WE DID DIFFERENTLY	KEEP
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐
_____	_____	☐

THE VERSION WE COOK NOW Once it settles

KEEPING IT

Fridge _____ Freezes _____

How to reheat it, properly _____

A PHOTOGRAPH OF IT, IF YOU WANT ONE

Cook once, eat twice.



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AS NEEDED

WHAT DOUBLING ACTUALLY NEEDS Yours beside it

THE RULE	WHAT WE DO
Doubles cleanly Stews, sauces, soups, braises, most bakes	
Does not double Anything fried or roasted — a crowded pan steams	
Season at the end Salt does not double neatly; taste twice	
Cool it fast Shallow trays, not a hot pot left on the side	
Freeze it flat Bags laid down freeze and thaw in a fraction of the time	
Label or lose it What, how many portions, and the date it went in	

DISHES THAT ARE BETTER THE NEXT DAY

DISHES THAT ARE NOT Cook these to eat

“Reheat thoroughly” is not an instruction

It is the line that produces dry chicken and a cold middle. Write the real one instead, per dish: what heat, in what, covered or not, with a splash of water or not, and how you know — steaming all the way through, not warm at the edges. Reheat once, and heat only what you are going to eat.

IN THE FREEZER Portions, and when it has to be eaten

WHAT	PORTIONS IN	BY

HOW WE REHEAT EACH OF THEM Per dish, in one line

When it goes wrong.



THE USUAL FIXES, AND YOURS What worked, in your kitchen

WHAT IS WRONG, AND WHAT TO DO WHAT WORKED FOR US

Too salty

Bulk it out — more liquid, potato, rice, unsalted stock. Then acid, then something sweet. Nothing removes salt.

Too thin

Reduce it uncovered, or a teaspoon of cornflour slaked in cold water. Never tip dry flour into hot liquid.

Too thick

Loosen with the cooking water, stock or milk, a splash at a time, off the boil.

Split or curdled

Off the heat. A spoonful of cold liquid, whisked hard. Or blitz it and start the sauce again around it.

Bland

Salt first. Then acid — lemon, vinegar. Then fat. Sweet and heat last. Nine times in ten it was salt or acid.

Meat dry

Slice it thin across the grain and sauce it. Next time: lower heat, take it out earlier, let it rest.

Burnt on the bottom

Tip what is good into a clean pan without scraping. The burnt taste travels; the pan does not come back.

Cake sunk or raw inside

Oven too hot, or the door opened early. Check the real temperature on page 1 and the date on the baking powder.

Taste it earlier than you think

Almost everything on this list is recoverable if it is caught while there is still time to act — and almost nothing is, once it is on the plate. Taste at the start, in the middle and before it leaves the pan; season in small amounts each time rather than once at the end, which is how things end up too salty in the first place.

WHAT WE GET WRONG, AGAIN AND AGAIN

WHAT FIXED IT

THINGS WORTH LEARNING PROPERLY One at a ti...

Cooking for other people.



One oven, four dishes, and everything wants a different temperature

This is why dinner is late, and it is arithmetic rather than skill. Write every dish down with the heat it needs and how long it takes, then decide what shares the oven, what is happy ten degrees off, what can come out and sit covered, and what is cooked on the hob instead. Anything that is fine at room temperature is a dish that stops competing.

THE OVEN, DISH BY DISH Tick what can share

DISH	TEMP	MINS	SHARE
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐

Sitting down at

So the oven goes on at

FINE AT ROOM TEMPERATURE First, then forget

COUNTED BACK FROM THE TABLE

THE DAY BEFORE

THE MORNING

AN HOUR BEFORE

THE LAST TEN MINUTES

WHO IS COMING, AND WHAT THEY CANNOT EAT

The one rule worth keeping: do not cook something for the first time for guests. Cook it once for yourself, put it on page 2, and then it is a recipe rather than a gamble.

The ones we actually cook.



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ONCE

NOT ALPHABETICAL Two dishes against each, that is enough

WHEN YOU NEED	THIS	OR THIS
Quick, on a weeknight		
Feeds a crowd		
Freezes well		
Cheap		
When somebody is ill		
Uses what is already in		
Worth showing off		
Nobody has to be asked twice		

Nobody stands in a kitchen at half past six thinking of a dish by name. They think “something quick”, or “something that uses the mince in the fridge”. An index that answers the question people actually ask is the one that gets used.

THE RUT What we cook too often

WHAT TO TRY NEXT One a fortnight is plenty

TRIED, AND NOT KEEPING Say so, and stop re-cooking it

THE DISH THIS HOUSE IS KNOWN FOR

Written down before it is lost.



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AS NEEDED

Family recipes die in the gap between “some flour” and a number

The person who cooks it does not use a recipe, so there is nothing to photocopy. The only way to keep it is to stand next to them while they cook it and write down what you see — weighing things as they go in, and asking the questions below, which are the ones whose answers never make it onto a card.

ASK, WHILE THEY ARE COOKING

- ☐ How much is “a bit”? Show me in your hand, then we will weigh it
- ☐ Which pan? This one, or the big one?
- ☐ How high is the heat, really — can I hear it?
- ☐ How do you know when it is done, without looking at a clock?
- ☐ What do you do if it goes wrong?
- ☐ What did your mother do differently?
- ☐ What do you always serve it with?
- ☐ What would you never put in it?

WHOSE RECIPE THIS IS

Cooked by _____

Written down on _____

Where they got it _____

What they call it _____

WHAT I SAW THEM DO The things they did not say out loud

WHAT I WEIGHED, WHILE THEY POURED

THE BIT THEY COULD NOT EXPLAIN Write it anyway

Then cook it once yourself, from your notes, while you can still ring them up — and put the finished version on a page 2.

The numbers you keep looking up.



CUPS TO GRAMS Weight beats volume, every time		
WHAT	MEASURE	IS ABOUT
Plain flour	1 cup	125 g
Caster sugar	1 cup	200 g
Brown sugar, packed	1 cup	220 g
Butter	1 cup / 2 sticks	225 g
Rice, uncooked	1 cup	185 g
Water or milk	1 cup	240 ml
Tablespoon / teaspoon	1 tbsp / 1 tsp	15 ml / 5 ml

A cup of flour can vary by a fifth depending on whether it was scooped or spooned, which is most of the difference between two people baking the same recipe. If there are scales in the kitchen, use them.

OVEN, THREE WAYS Fan is about 20°C lower			
GAS	CONVENTIONAL	FAN	FAHRENHEIT
Gas 4	180°C	160°C fan	350°F
Gas 6	200°C	180°C fan	400°F
Gas 7	220°C	200°C fan	425°F

TINS WE HAVE, IN BOTH			
Round		Square	
Loaf		Roasting	

SWAPS THAT WORK IN THIS KITCHEN Tested, not hopeful	
INSTEAD OF	WE USE

SWAPS THAT DID NOT WORK	

WHERE THINGS ARE Spices, tins, the good oil	

WORTH BUYING PROPERLY Only three	